

Top Open Source Tools *for* Web Optimisation

A website that allows visitors easy access and smooth navigation is a Web designer's dream. While search engine optimisation may draw visitors to a given site, it is Web optimisation that keeps the visitor there. This article takes a look at the process of Web optimisation and the best open source tools for it.



Web optimisation is regarded as a scientific approach to improving the performance of a website. It is termed as the process of using controlled experimentation to improve a website's ability to drive business goals. During the process of Web optimisation, changes are incorporated so that websites rank higher in search engine results pages (SERPS). The process of Web optimisation includes processes such as adding relevant keywords and phrases to the website, editing meta tags and image tags, optimising other components of the website to ensure that it is accessible to search engines, and making overall changes that get the website indexed by all search engines with all possible user typed keywords to crawl information from the Web.

Web optimisation combines the disciplines of online marketing and site performance tuning to attain the competitive advantage necessary on the Internet. User optimisation goes hand in hand with Web optimisation. User optimisation involves creating a memorable user experience, so that users can read the content on the site and take the right steps. Optimisation of content for users increases conversion rates and boosts search rankings. According to *MarketingSherpa*, "Over 80 per cent of marketers consider increasing overall conversion a dominant priority for their Web optimisation programmes."

The process of Web optimisation

Web optimisation uses the same principles as conversion rate optimisation. In fact, both these terms can be used interchangeably. Web optimisation is best defined as an ongoing process that, over time, makes the website more effective and valuable for a company and the end users. Improving the Web optimisation performance is a continual process, and has five stages (Figure 1).

1. **Hypothesis establishment:** Analytics review is the fundamental part to be done at regular intervals, to determine the pages that are performing well and those that are not. It is recommended that you acquire qualitative feedback from visitors, and then brainstorm to figure out the potential causes of poor performance to draw up a list of Web optimisations to test.
2. **Prioritise:** After building the list of potential optimisations, it is of utmost importance to rate them as per priority, and rank them in order of their anticipated positive impact on the performance of the website.
3. **Testing optimisations:** A/B testing is the next stage in Web optimisation. It is best to keep the changes that significantly optimise the performance and user experience, and ignore those that are not enhancing Web performance.
4. **Test analysis:** Reviewing the testing data to determine which hypotheses are true and which aren't is the next stage. By implementing the best tests, website optimisation becomes better and misleading data is eradicated.
5. **Website optimisation:** This stage involves reviewing winning tests, and acquiring more learning from tests that didn't make it.

It is important to understand that website optimisation is a never ending process, and produces the best results by testing, retesting and making changes at regular intervals of time.

The top ten elements of Web optimisation

Web optimisation is much more significant than search engine optimisation. It is all about managing and optimising the crucial elements on the website. Here are the top ten elements of Web optimisation.

1. **Keyword research:** This is very important and should be done even *before* you start building the website. Everything